The Bridge Trap: Why Mind-Merging Technology Cannot Solve the Problem of Other Minds

Brandon M. Sergent

Abstract

David Pearce proposes that reversible thalamic bridges will one day permit mind-melding between subjects and so lay the problem of other minds to rest. William Hirstein argues on independent grounds that direct access to another person's conscious states ("mindmelding") is possible and that the privacy of consciousness is a dispensable dogma. The craniopagus Hogan twins, joined by a functioning thalamic bridge, and the existing brain-to-brain interface literature are offered as early evidence. This paper argues that no bridge, at any bandwidth, can solve the problem of other minds, and that the attempt manufactures worse problems than the one it targets. The core argument is a dilemma. To the extent two bridged parties remain distinct, neither can verify that the other feels, because every signal arrives inside a single phenomenal field. To the extent they merge, the bridge has not verified an other mind but produced a third one, and a reversible bridge is by construction a mechanism for ending that third subject over its own objection. Beyond the horns, further failures follow: the bridge cannot authenticate the provenance of transmitted experience and can present the suffering of a fictional victim as phenomenally indistinguishable from genuine transmission; any instrument that can confirm suffering can deny it; compulsory neural correlation can produce aversive conditioning and compliance without compassion; the proposal inherits externalism's structure of making suffering secondary to measurement; and the boundary it dissolves is the very thing that makes other minds morally inviolable. Experiential Empiricism's treatment of other minds is defended as the stronger position precisely because it treats the epistemic limit as a protective boundary rather than an engineering defect.

Keywords: problem of other minds, thalamic bridge, brain-to-brain interface, mindmelding, personal identity, fission, Experiential Empiricism, suffering, neuroethics, externalism

Independent Researcher

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1. Introduction

The problem of other minds is the question of how I can know that any being other than myself genuinely experiences anything, rather than merely behaving as if it does. The traditional answers are inferential. The argument from analogy holds that other bodies resemble mine and behave as mine does, so they probably house experience as mine does. The inference to the best explanation holds that inner lives are the best account of the behavior we observe (Hyslop, *Other Minds*). Both are inferences, and Thomas Nagel's *What Is It Like to Be a Bat?* states the limit they run into: the subjective character of an experience is accessible only from the single point of view that has it, and no quantity of objective, third-person description reaches it.

A technological answer has now been proposed that claims to bypass inference entirely. David Pearce argues that future reversible thalamic bridges will allow direct mind-melding between subjects, and that this "should lay to rest the philosophical Problem of Other Minds" (Pearce, *The Hedonistic Imperative*). The proposal is not idle. William Hirstein has argued at book length that one person directly experiencing another's conscious states, which he calls mindmelding, is physically possible, and that the supposed privacy of consciousness is a dogma standing in the way of a physicalist account of mind (Hirstein, *Mindmelding*). Two lines of evidence are cited. The craniopagus Hogan twins, Krista

and Tatiana, are joined by a functioning thalamic bridge and report shared taste, shared touch, and cross-body vision (Cochrane, *A Case of Shared Consciousness*). And brain-to-brain interfaces already transmit decoded signals between human nervous systems (Rao et al., *A Direct Brain-to-Brain Interface in Humans*; Jiang et al., *BrainNet*).

This paper argues that the proposal fails, and fails structurally rather than for want of better engineering. A bridge cannot solve the problem of other minds at any setting of its bandwidth dial, and the closer it comes to the appearance of a solution, the worse the harms it introduces. The argument is developed as a dilemma in section 3, worked through both horns in sections 4 through 6, extended to five downstream failure modes in sections 7 through 10, and contrasted in section 11 with the treatment of other minds in Experiential Empiricism (Sergent, *Epistemic Honesty and the Other Minds Question in Experiential Empiricism*), which is defended as the stronger position.

2. The Proposal and What It Promises

The bridge proposal has a strong form and a weak form, and they are usually run together. The strong form is Pearce's: a high-bandwidth, reversible thalamic interface that fuses two streams of experience closely enough that one subject directly undergoes what the other undergoes. The weak form is the current engineering reality: low-bandwidth transfer of decoded neural signals from one brain to another. Rao and colleagues transmitted a motor intention from a sender's cortex, read by electroencephalography, into a receiver's motor cortex by transcranial magnetic stimulation, producing an involuntary hand movement (Rao et al., *A Direct Brain-to-Brain Interface in Humans*). Jiang and colleagues networked three people into a shared Tetris-like task by the same family of methods (Jiang et al., *BrainNet*). Earlier work established the principle across rat brains (Pais-Vieira et al., *A Brain-to-Brain Interface for Real-Time Sharing of Sensorimotor Information*).

The promise common to both forms is that direct neural connection converts an inference into a perception. Instead of reasoning that another being probably feels, I would feel what it feels, and the problem would dissolve. Hirstein makes the philosophical version explicit: if the self is identified with the executive functions of the prefrontal cortex, and conscious states are located in posterior regions, then one agent's executive systems could in principle be connected to another agent's conscious states, and privacy would turn out to be a contingent fact of wiring rather than a necessary feature of mind (Hirstein, *Mindmelding*). The Hogan twins are taken as proof of concept that nature has already built the connection in at least one case.

The promise is what this paper denies. The sections that follow grant the engineering in full, including its most ambitious extrapolation, and show that the philosophical conclusion does not follow at any point along the way.

3. The Dilemma the Bridge Cannot Escape

The whole case reduces to a single dilemma that holds at every level of connection. Run a bridge between two people and exactly one of two things is true at any given moment. To the extent they remain two people, neither can know that the other feels, because the bridge delivers its contents into one phenomenal field at a time, and a content occurring in my field is my experience whatever its causal origin. To the extent they have genuinely become one person, the problem of other minds has not been answered, it has been dissolved by deleting one of its terms, because there is no longer an other to be in question. Experience is self-proving only from the inside, and there is only ever one inside per field.

A bridge is a bandwidth setting on this dilemma, and it loses at both ends of the dial. Turn the bandwidth toward maximum and the two fields approach fusion into a single new field, at which point the bridge has manufactured a mind rather than verified the two it joined. Turn the bandwidth down and the transfer becomes a signal that the receiver's field renders into a sensation, which establishes that the apparatus transmitted and translated a request, not that anything was felt at the far end. There is no intermediate setting at which the dilemma relaxes, because the dilemma is not about how much information moves. It is about the fact that verification of experience is itself experiential, the same constraint that defeats every other route to mind-independent confirmation (Sergent, *The Magic Window: Why Direct Access Changes Nothing*). The remaining sections work out each horn and the harms specific to it.

4. The High-Information Horn Does Not Cross the Boundary

Take the connection as rich as you like, short of fusion. When I receive another nervous system's signals through an interface, I undergo new patterns within my own phenomenal field. Those patterns may correlate tightly with the other party's reports. Correlation inside my field is not access to a field outside it. A thermometer's reading correlates with temperature without the reading being the temperature, and a vivid merged-state experience correlates with the partner's report without being the partner's experience.

This is the boundary problem, and the bridge relocates it rather than removing it. To establish that an experience exists outside my access, I would have to occupy a standpoint outside all experience and confirm from there that experience is present, which is incoherent, since the confirming standpoint would itself be experiential. This is the same structural result reached by the Magic Window argument, where even a device that inserted perfect knowledge of mind-independent reality directly into consciousness would yield only more experience, never the mind-independence it was supposed to certify (Sergent, *The Magic Window*). Nagel's point arrives at the same wall from the other side: the subjective character of the bat's experience is not made available by any amount of objective information about the bat (Nagel, *What Is It Like to Be a Bat?*). A bridge is more objective information delivered more intimately. Intimacy of delivery does not change its category.

Hirstein's response is to deny that the boundary is real, treating privacy as a dogma to be dissolved by neuroscience (Hirstein, *Mindmelding*). But the denial proves the point. Hirstein can dissolve privacy

only by first identifying the self with one set of brain regions and consciousness with another, and then declaring that connecting the first to the second counts as one self experiencing the other's states. That is a stipulation about how to redescribe a wiring diagram, not a demonstration that the lived boundary between subjects has been crossed. It assumes the physicalist identification that the problem of other minds exists to question, which is the externalist move examined in section 10.

5. The Fusion Horn Manufactures a Third Subject

Now take the connection to its limit. Pearce stresses that the bridge is reversible, and offers reversibility as a safeguard (Pearce, *The Hedonistic Imperative*). It is the opposite of a safeguard, and seeing why requires taking the maximum-bandwidth case literally.

Run a full connection between two subjects and you do not have two subjects sharing a window. You have one subject with a unified field, its own preferences, and its own capacity to report suffering. The philosophical resources for describing this already exist. Derek Parfit analyzed fission, the division of one person into two psychologically continuous successors, and concluded that personal identity is not what matters in survival, since identity cannot branch but the relation that carries what we care about can (Parfit, *Reasons and Persons*). A maximal bridge is fission run backwards: two streams converging into one. The convergent subject is to its predecessors what Parfit's two successors are to their predecessor, a distinct locus that the identity question cannot tidily absorb. Star Trek's *Voyager* dramatized exactly this case in the episode "Tuvix," in which a merge produces a single new individual who asks, coherently and with evident valence, not to be taken apart (Berman et al., *Tuvix*).

Apply reversibility to this subject. Severing the bridge does not return two people to a prior state as though nothing had lived in between. It ends the convergent subject who existed while the bridge was live, and that subject can report suffering at the prospect of being ended. Reversibility means the protocol is built to override that report by design. On any framework that treats suffering reports as primary data rather than as claims awaiting external license, disregarding the merged subject's plea in order to restore the originals is not a neutral undo. It is killing (Sergent, *The Hedonic Core Framework*). The bridge therefore does not merely fail to verify an other mind at its high end. It creates a new mind and installs a switch for disposing of it on command. The boundary that the bridge promised to overcome reappears as a fresh moral subject, and reversibility is the lever for erasing that subject.

6. The Low-Information Horn Transmits Signals, Not Feeling

The current engineering sits at the opposite end of the dial, and it fails differently without failing less. A connection that makes the receiver flinch when the sender is pinched has not shown the receiver the sender's pain. It has delivered a stimulus to the receiver on a schedule keyed to events at the sender. This is what the brain-to-brain interface literature actually demonstrates. Rao's interface caused a hand movement by stimulating motor cortex; it did not transport the sender's intention as a felt intention, it triggered a matching output (Rao et al., *A Direct Brain-to-Brain Interface in Humans*). BrainNet moved

game decisions between players as decoded bits rendered into the receiver's perception (Jiang et al., *BrainNet*).

Generalize the mechanism. Tickle one person's finger, transmit the decoded signal, and the receiver's finger reports a tickle. This establishes that the apparatus can encode, transmit, and re-present a request. It establishes nothing about whether anything is felt at the destination, because a sufficiently good signal-translator produces the same output whether or not a subject is home to feel it. Low-bandwidth bridging is wireheading with a second party in the loop, drug delivery synchronized to a protocol, and it is liable to be mistaken for telepathy precisely because the synchronization is convincing. The convincingness is the trap. A behavior that tracks the sender perfectly is exactly what a mindless relay would also produce, which is why the low end of the dial cannot discharge the burden of proof any more than the high end can.

7. The Provenance Trap: A Fictional Sufferer Feels Just as Real

The bridge faces a further failure that does not depend on bandwidth, fusion, or the reliability of its neural translation. It cannot authenticate the alleged source of the experience it delivers. Suppose a subject is connected to a suffering animal through a technologically perfect thalamic interface. The recipient experiences the animal's pain with extraordinary fidelity and emerges convinced that another being's suffering has become directly accessible. Now replace the animal with a synthetic generator that produces exactly the same phenomenal input. The recipient's experience remains unchanged. Only the proposed explanation of its origin differs. The first case involves an alleged suffering animal; the second involves an entirely fictional victim. Nothing about the intensity, immediacy, or qualitative character of the received experience distinguishes them.

This is the provenance trap. A bridge can transmit an experience without transmitting proof of its origin. The recipient may have excellent empirical reasons to trust the apparatus, its operators, and the evidence connecting the signal to a particular source. But those reasons remain inferential. They depend on observations, calibration, records, testimony, and assumptions about the causal chain. The bridge has not eliminated the original epistemic problem. It has added another apparatus whose claims require validation. A perfectly faithful phenomenal reproduction can still be a perfectly faithful reproduction of a fiction.

The distinction matters because the bridge's persuasive power is precisely what makes the error dangerous. Ordinary testimony can be challenged as mistaken or fabricated. A phenomenally overwhelming experience may instead be treated as self-authenticating: I felt the suffering, therefore the alleged sufferer must exist and must have suffered. But the conclusion does not follow. The reality of the recipient's experience establishes that the recipient experienced something. It does not establish the existence, identity, independence, or phenomenal condition of the subject to whom the apparatus attributes that experience. Phenomenal certainty about an occurrence cannot be converted into metaphysical certainty about its alleged provenance.

This also introduces an adversarial possibility. An operator could manufacture a suffering experience, attribute it to a nonexistent subject, and present the resulting conviction as evidence that the

subject exists. The recipient might become emotionally committed to protecting a victim who was never there. Such concern could be entirely sincere. Its sincerity would not authenticate its object. The same instrument that promises to make suffering undeniable could therefore manufacture both the apparent suffering and the purported sufferer, while leaving the recipient unable to distinguish the fabrication from an authentic transmission on phenomenal grounds alone.

The objection does not imply that brain-to-brain interfaces are useless or that their outputs cannot be supported by independent empirical evidence. It establishes the narrower and decisive point: **phenomenal fidelity is not provenance, and provenance is not proof of another independent phenomenal subject.** The bridge cannot certify its own interpretation of what it transmits. Its output remains experience, not an escape from the epistemic conditions of experience.

8. The Validation Trap: Any Gauge That Confirms Can Deny

Set the dilemma aside and grant, for argument, that a bridge counted as a test of suffering. The most dangerous failure mode appears immediately. Any instrument capable of validating suffering is equally capable of invalidating it, because a test that can return positive can return negative.

Consider the bridge as a gauge. A subject reports agony, the bridge is connected, and the expected correlate does not register. The technology now licenses the sentence that the externalist tradition has always wanted: your suffering failed the test, the readings are insufficient, you are not really hurting. This is not an abuse of the device. It is the device working as designed, since the entire point was to convert a subjective report into an objective verdict, and an objective verdict has a negative branch.

The historical record on instruments of this shape is uniform. Intelligence testing, introduced to help struggling students, became an engine of eugenic classification. Psychiatric diagnosis, meant to relieve suffering, became a tool for pathologizing dissent. The polygraph, sold as objective truth detection, became an interrogation cudgel. Functional brain imaging, offered to illuminate experience, became courtroom and clinical evidence that a given person's suffering "is not real" because the expected regions did not light up. The pattern is structural, not accidental, and a bridge inherits it. Under report-honoring frameworks the burden lies on whoever would dismiss a suffering report. The bridge inverts the burden, requiring the sufferer to register on the gauge or be dismissed, which converts moral patients from beings whose testimony matters intrinsically into test subjects whose experience awaits external validation (Sergent, *The Torture Clip Maximizer: Calling Someone Solipsist Is Not a Moral Flex*).

9. Compulsory Correlation Is Not Compassion

Empathy and compassion, as moral phenomena, are acts. Responding to a suffering report is a choice to grant the report uptake, and the choice presupposes a separate subject whose testimony I elect to honor. A bridge replaces the act with a state. Instead of choosing to weigh your suffering, I am made to undergo a correlate of it by forced connection. This is not an intensification of empathy but the removal of empathy as a moral category, since what was an election becomes a wiring condition.

Once minds are reliably connectable, a specific set of controls becomes not only possible but natural to propose. Mandatory empathy connections so offenders "feel the harm they caused." Enforced affective states so dissidents "understand why they are wrong." Authorized disconnection of subminds judged harmful to a collective. Override of an individual's states for the good of a merged system. Each of these reads as reasonable once one accepts that bridging solves other minds and renders their states accessible, because accessibility invites maintenance, and maintenance requires judgments about which states to keep and which to repair. A suffering submind becomes a malfunctioning module, disconnection becomes a fix, and override becomes optimization. The multi-person brain-to-brain interface literature has already begun cataloguing these as live neuroethical hazards rather than science-fiction worries (Hildt, *Multi-Person Brain-To-Brain Interfaces: Ethical Issues*). The bridge does not prevent this trajectory. It supplies the infrastructure for it.

The coercive potential is more fundamental than the institutional applications just described. Consider a device that makes a recipient experience pain whenever another person suffers. Its functional relationship to the recipient is comparable to an extraordinarily sophisticated shock collar synchronized to an alleged victim's condition. Instead of an electrical shock, it delivers an arbitrarily rich phenomenal state. The recipient may be told that the experience is another being's suffering, but what the apparatus directly establishes is that the recipient can be made to suffer. The recipient's subsequent behavior does not establish whether compassion, fear, aversion, identification, or simple compliance motivated the response.

The distinction between making someone feel suffering and making someone care about another sufferer is essential. An aversive stimulus can condition behavior without producing the moral judgment supposedly being taught. A person may act to stop the stimulus, avoid its recurrence, satisfy the operator, or escape the circumstances of its administration. Those responses can outwardly resemble compassion without establishing concern for the alleged victim. No degree of phenomenal intensity logically converts imposed suffering into freely adopted moral recognition. A whip can produce compliance; making the whip neurologically elaborate does not change the underlying inference.

The provenance trap makes this problem worse. The operator need not connect the recipient to an actual sufferer. A fictional victim can be paired with a synthetic suffering signal, and the recipient can be conditioned to respond to that invented subject as though its suffering had been directly witnessed. The apparatus can manufacture the aversive experience, supply the narrative identifying its supposed source, and reinforce the desired response. It can thereby manufacture a conviction that feels grounded in immediate experience while leaving the existence of the purported victim entirely unestablished. The apparent moral authority of the transmission becomes a property of the operator's control over the experience and its interpretation.

This is not an allegation that Pearce intends such coercion, nor that every possible bridge would be used this way. It is a structural objection to treating imposed phenomenal access as a substitute for epistemic justification or ethical persuasion. A device that can make someone undergo an experience cannot, by that fact alone, establish whose experience it represents or why the recipient should adopt the operator's interpretation. The machine can impose a state. It cannot manufacture the logical warrant that the state is supposed to provide. **Compelled identification is not authenticated testimony, and conditioned compliance is not compassion.**

10. The Bridge Inherits Externalism's Structure

The deepest problem is that the bridge proposal is externalist in form. Externalism, in the sense used here, is the practice of treating direct experience as insufficient and demanding validation against something posited outside experience, with experiential evidence ranked as secondary to the posited external (Sergent, *Explanatory Bedrock and Evaluative Foundation*). Hirstein's program is openly of this kind: its motivation is to remove an obstacle to a physicalist account of consciousness, so that conscious states can be treated as locatable, measurable items connectable by hardware (Hirstein, *Mindmelding*). Suffering, on this picture, becomes real in proportion to its measurability.

This is the same structure that has always done the dismissing. The vivisectionist did not need to deny that the animal writhed. He needed only to require that suffering pass a materialist legitimacy test, objective significance rather than mere subjective occurrence, and to find the test unmet (Sergent, *The Torture Clip Maximizer*). The bridge reproduces the structure with better equipment. It also inherits the regress that always attends it. Even a perfect neural correlation between two systems establishes only that correlation occurred. To show that the correlated states are experiences rather than mere information processing would require a further instrument to certify the consciousness of the first, and so on without end. Adding measurement tools cannot close a gap that is about the standing of experience relative to all third-person observation, because every tool operates within the third-person domain that the problem is about. This is the binding-problem result generalized: brain-experience correlations are foundational observations, and demanding a substrate beneath them to explain them is the error, not the solution (Sergent, *The Binding Problem as Axiom Violation*).

11. The Alternative: A Limit Worth Keeping

Experiential Empiricism accepts the problem of other minds without flinching and without promising a future device that will end it. Other minds cannot be proven to exist outside one's own field, because the proof would have to be experiential and so would never reach outside experience. This is a logical limit, not a temporary gap (Sergent, *Epistemic Honesty and the Other Minds Question in Experiential Empiricism*). The response is to assume other minds as a moral commitment rather than to prove them as a metaphysical fact. When a being reports suffering and behaves consistently with suffering, treat the pattern as suffering, not because external existence has been demonstrated but because honoring the report is the safer error.

The asymmetry of errors is the whole argument. The error available to this framework is treating a non-experiencing system as if it suffers, which costs excess care given to something that may not need it. The error available to externalism, including its bridge-based form, is dismissing genuine suffering that failed a validation criterion, which is the structure under every atrocity of record. One error mode overshoots compassion. The other licenses cruelty. The asymmetry is not sentimental, it follows from where each framework places the burden of proof, and it is why a framework grounded in the single axiom of valenced experience treats suffering reports as primary and uncheckable rather than as secondary and pending (Sergent, *Logic as Structural Valence: Why Experiential Empiricism's Two*

Axioms Are One).

Keeping the boundary is what makes the commitment binding. If another's suffering could be proven externally, its absence could be proven too, and the same gauge that confirmed a mind could certify its malfunction or its expendability. A subject that cannot fail a test cannot be disqualified by one. The unknowability of other minds, treated by the bridge proposal as a defect to engineer away, is the feature that makes respect for other minds obligatory rather than optional. The bridge offers to remove that unknowability. What it would actually remove is the moral necessity of treating other minds as inviolable.

12. Conclusion

The problem of other minds is not the kind of problem that yields to more measurement, because it is a problem about the standing of experience relative to all measurement. A bridge cannot escape the dilemma that frames it. While the parties stay distinct it transmits signals into one field and proves nothing about the other, and when they merge it produces a third subject and proves nothing about the two, while installing in the name of reversibility a mechanism for ending the subject it made. Beyond that dilemma, the bridge cannot authenticate the provenance of the experience it delivers: an entirely fictional sufferer could be made phenomenally indistinguishable from a genuine one. Any gauge that can confirm suffering can deny it. Compulsory correlation can impose pain, condition compliance, and manufacture apparent identification without establishing compassion. The proposal inherits externalism's ranking of suffering beneath measurement, and it dissolves the boundary that makes other minds matter. Experiential Empiricism is the stronger position because it declines the bridge's promise, treats the epistemic limit as a protective boundary, and honors suffering reports as primary data requiring no external license. The bridge is not the solution to the problem of other minds. It is the problem rebuilt in more sophisticated form, with a kill switch and a programmable whip added.

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